

A REFLECTION SHEET FROM MANDYC.

The 5 Questions

*Five questions executives should be able to answer before
a capital event — raise, restructure, or list.*

MANDY CHEUNG · SFC TYPE 6 LICENSED
60+ TRANSACTIONS · US\$200M+ IN DEAL VALUE
HKEX & NASDAQ

WHY THESE QUESTIONS

The gaps that matter live somewhere else.

Lawyers catch structural gaps. Auditors catch financial ones. The gaps that actually kill the raise or the listing live somewhere else: in the leader.

The CEO who can't hold the line when a board member pushes hard. The founder who freezes when due diligence surfaces something ugly. The executive whose decision quality degrades as pressure compresses. The leader running on adrenaline by month 14.

These are the five questions I'd ask any executive sitting in front of me, six months out from a capital event. No scoring. No software. Just questions worth sitting with.

Print this. Annotate it. Write what comes up. The honest answers are the entry point — to a conversation with your co-founder, your board chair, your coach, or yourself.

Capital Narrative Conviction

Your equity story isn't a slide deck. It's a nervous system event. When a sophisticated investor pushes back on your valuation, your body responds before your mind catches up. The leader who holds the story under pressure isn't the one with better data. It's the one whose conviction lives deeper than the script.

THE QUESTION

When you state your company's valuation to a room of sophisticated investors, where does your conviction come from?

A PROMPT TO SIT WITH

Think about the last time you stated your valuation out loud. Where did you feel it in your body? Any tightening? Any impulse to qualify or hedge? That's data.

YOUR NOTES

Decision-Making Under Pressure

A capital event compresses decision timelines. Term sheets arrive Friday with a Monday answer expected. Due diligence surfaces something ugly the week before signing. The leader who freezes or defaults to reactive thinking costs the company money or the deal itself. The question isn't whether pressure comes. It's what your nervous system does in the first 60 seconds.

THE QUESTION

When the deal compresses (term sheet, DD finding, walk-away threat), what happens first?

A PROMPT TO SIT WITH

Think about the last time a high-pressure decision landed without warning. What did your body do first? That response, before the strategic mind kicked in, is the real answer.

YOUR NOTES

Board and Investor Communication

Sophisticated capital tests the leader through pushback. A board member's bad idea. An investor's overreach. A co-investor's pressure to accept worse terms. The leader who can't hold the line loses leverage that doesn't come back. The skill is holding the line while staying in relationship.

THE QUESTION

When you disagree with a board member or investor on something that matters, what happens?

A PROMPT TO SIT WITH

Think about the last time you disagreed with someone who had more leverage than you. Did you say what you actually thought, or a version of it? Notice what you edited out.

YOUR NOTES

Personal Operating System

A capital event is an 18-month compression. The leader without a real operating system breaks somewhere: burnout, home, or the deal itself. Discipline, state control, and recovery aren't soft. They're load-bearing. They're the infrastructure that keeps judgment intact when everything else is compressing.

THE QUESTION

Under sustained pressure (months, not days), does your system hold or start to break?

A PROMPT TO SIT WITH

What broke first during the last sustained high-pressure window? Sleep? Decision quality? The closest relationship? The thing that breaks first is the thing your current system doesn't protect.

YOUR NOTES

Strategic Clarity

The capital event is a tool, not a goal. The leader who forgets that optimizes for the raise itself. By then, the deal has reshaped the company in ways nobody wanted. Hiring, spending, structuring: all bent toward the raise instead of the business the raise was meant to build.

THE QUESTION

Is the capital event a tool in service of a thesis, or has it become the thesis itself?

A PROMPT TO SIT WITH

If the capital event disappeared tomorrow, what would your company be optimizing for? If you can't answer that cleanly, the deal has already reshaped the strategy.

YOUR NOTES

WHAT NEXT

The honest answers are the entry point.

If one of these questions exposed something — a hesitation, an avoidance, a gap you hadn't named — that's the data. Not what you wrote on the line. What you noticed before you wrote anything at all.

When you're ready to see where you actually stand against all five dimensions, take the scored version: ten minutes, your band placement, dimension-by-dimension insight on where the work is.

[MANDYC.ME/EXECUTIVE-READINESS](https://mandyc.me/executive-readiness)

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